

Capsicum



HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Capsicums include both sweet peppers and chillies: colourful, heat-loving members of the tomato and potato family. In their native climate they are perennial plants, but in Britain they are grown as tender annuals and are most reliable under glass or in a warm, sheltered position. Green peppers are edible but are still an immature stage; if left to ripen they change colour and, in many varieties, become sweeter or hotter and more deeply flavoured. That extra flavour comes at a cost, because ripe-coloured fruit take longer to develop and the plant produces fewer new peppers while they mature. The crop is therefore a balance between earlier, heavier green harvests and later, smaller harvests of fully coloured fruit.

Quick facts



Sow

Feb – Mar



Harvest

Aug – Oct



Germination

14–21 days



Depth

Set at the same level as in the pot.



Row spacing

45 cm between rows



Plant spacing

Between plants: 45 cm; compact varieties 30 cm



Yield per plant

6–10 fruits



Ready in

About 18 weeks from sowing

Growing calendar



Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high



Sun

5/5



Water

4/5



Nutrition

4/5

Recommended varieties

CALIFORNIA WONDER

The block-shaped red and green fruits have a mild flavour – a reliable open-pollinated variety.

REDSKIN

A compact sweet pepper for pots, bags or beds in a sheltered spot.

NEW ACE

A good all-purpose pepper – early, high yielding and more tolerant of cool conditions than most varieties.

GYPSY

An early F1 sweet pepper with pale green fruits that ripen red.

MARCONI ROSSA

A long sweet pepper, pale green at first and ripening red.

ORANGE BABY

A smaller, sweet-fruited pepper on a compact plant.

HABANERO

A small orange chilli with extreme heat.

Key risks



POOR FRUIT SET

Flowers may fail to set during cold, excessive heat or drought.



RED SPIDER MITE

Sweet peppers can develop pale mottling and bronzing when red spider mites feed beneath leaves.



BLOSSOM END ROT

Brown patches appear at the bottom of the fruit – a frequent problem where growing bags are used.



SLUGS

Slugs may damage young plants and late, slow-ripening fruit near the soil surface.



Growing & harvesting

Give young plants reliable warmth.

Under cover is the most dependable UK route, especially in cooler areas.

Choose green or ripe-coloured harvests.

Early picking encourages more fruit; full colour usually gives deeper flavour.

Soil & preparation

1. Use fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil or peat-free potting compost. Choose warmth and shelter; avoid cold wet roots.
2. Pots, growing bags or greenhouse beds suit the crop. Outdoor success needs a particularly warm, sheltered site.

Sowing & planting

1 Raise in warmth



Sow under cover in February or March with steady warmth. Keep the strongest seedling and pot on carefully, or buy young plants to grow on.

2 Set the final plant



Harden off before moving outdoors after frost danger, when soil is warm. Set at pot depth and water well; protect until weather settles.

Rows 45 cm between rows

Plants Between plants: 45 cm; compact varieties 30 cm

Sow in warmth in February–March: sweet peppers at 18–21°C, chillies around 21°C. Later sweet-pepper sowings suit outdoor crops. Plant after frost risk.

Looking after the crop

1. Water regularly at the roots without leaving compost sodden. Mulch to keep moisture even and keep fruit dry to reduce rot. Ventilate in hot weather without chilling young plants.
2. Use an organic potassium-rich feed as fruits swell. Stake and loosely tie tall or heavily laden plants. Check leaf undersides for red spider mite and introduce suitable biological control early if needed. In hot weather, damp down the greenhouse floor while maintaining airflow.

Harvesting & storage

- Cut glossy green fruit for an earlier, heavier crop, or leave it to reach the variety's mature colour for fuller flavour. Full ripening can take another two to four weeks and usually reduces the number of new fruits produced.
- Cut with a short stalk rather than pulling. For drying, use sound, fully ripe chillies; spread or hang them in a warm, dry, airy place. Partly coloured fruit can go mouldy, and any mouldy fruit should be discarded. Late peppers ripen slowly as autumn cools.

Pests & diseases

Problem	What to look for	What to do
POOR FRUIT SET	Flowers fail to set, especially in cold.	Maintain warmth; avoid drought, overheating and cold checks.
RED SPIDER MITE	Pale mottling, bronzing; mites beneath leaves.	Identify early; use suitable predatory mites under cover.
BLOSSOM END ROT	Brown sunken patch at fruit base.	Keep root moisture even; avoid dry growing bags.
SLUGS	Seedlings or low fruit are chewed.	Inspect and hand-pick; support fruit clear of soil.
APHID	Colonies on tender shoots and leaves.	Squash damaging colonies and encourage natural predators.
Whitefly	Small white flies; sticky or sooty leaves.	Inspect new plants; use suitable biological control under cover.
Grey Mould	Grey fluffy mould on damaged tissue.	Remove infected tissue; ventilate and avoid wet fruit.
ANTHRACNOSE	Dark, sunken lesions on fruit or foliage.	Remove affected material; keep fruit dry and seek diagnosis.
CUTWORM	Young plants are severed at the base.	Use seedling collars; inspect nearby soil.

Final tips



Regularly picking some green peppers frees the plant to set more fruit.



Use gloves when handling hot chillies and avoid touching your eyes.